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Author(s): Ruby Lal

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of a Princess's
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Ruby Lal

AFTER THE BATTLE OF PANIPAT in 1526, which gave Babur, the first Mughal king, a foothold in India, his close friend, Khvajeh Kilan, expressed a desire to return to his home in Kabul. As Babur (reluctantly) gave him permission to go, he asked him to carry “valuable presents and curiosities [*tuhfeh va hadyeh*] of Hind” to his relations and other people in Kabul.¹

Two generations later, when asked to record her memories of the Mughal forefathers for the imperial history, the *Akbarnama*, Babur’s daughter, Gulbadan Banu Begum, reconstructed Babur’s conversation with Khvajeh Kilan as follows:

I shall write a list, and you will distribute them [the gifts] according to it. . . . To each begam is to be delivered as follows: one special dancing-girl of the dancing-girls of Sultan Ibrahim [Ibrahim Lodi, the king Babur defeated at Panipat], with one gold plate full of jewels—ruby and pearl, cornelian and diamond, emerald and turquoise, topaz and cat’s-eye—and two small mother-o’-pearl trays full of *ashrafis*, and on two other trays *shahrukhis*, and all sorts of stuffs by nines—that is, four trays and one plate. Take a dancing-girl and another plate of jewels, and one each of *ashrafis* and *shahrukhis*, and present, in accordance with my directions, to my elder relations the very plate of jewels and the self-same dancing-girl which I have given for them [*sic*]. I have made other gifts; convey these afterwards. Let them divide and present jewels and *ashrafis* and *shahrukhis* and stuffs to my sisters

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and children and the *harams* and kinsmen, and to the begams and aghas and nurses and foster-brethren and ladies, and to all who pray for me.²

Gulbadan's record of her father's inventory is striking for several reasons. It brings to life questions of correct deportment in the preparation of gifts and the manner of presenting (and accepting) them—so central to the sensibilities of the Timurid-Mughal world. It is particularly notable for depicting Babur's domestic life. The Begum gives us glimpses of the range of Babur's domestic relationships and associations, with the old as well as the young. The list of gifts is a pointer to the centrality and the hierarchical character of these relationships. Babur gave clear instructions about what should be given to whom and in what order. So the elder relations (*vali-u-ni`matan*) were to be given the following presents first: a dancing girl, a plate of jewels, and a plate each of *ashrafis* and *shahrulkhis* (designation for coins), to be followed by "other gifts" that Babur had listed for them. Similarly his sisters, kinsmen and their wives, heads of households, nurses, and children were to receive presents later in accordance with Babur's list. The Begum's memoir pays a great deal of attention to such illustrative inventories. In her elucidation, the details of presents and invitations serve not merely as a descriptive catalog, but as symbols of the privileges of seniority. They index the creation and maintenance of hierarchical relationships, as well as the importance of building alliances and reinforcing kinship solidarities.

At another point in her memoir, Gulbadan discusses the time Humayun, the second Mughal king, spent with the royal women when his court was settled for a while in Agra:

On court days [*ruzhaye divan*], which were Sundays and Tuesdays, he used to go to the other side of the river. During his stay in the garden, *ajam* (Dil-dar Begam) and my sisters and the ladies (*haraman*) were often in his company. Of all the tents, Ma'suma Sultan Begam's was at the top of the row. Next came Gul-rang Begam's, and *ajam*'s was in the same place. Then the tent of my mother, Gul-barg Begam and of Bega Begam and the others. They set up the offices (*kar-khanaha*) and got them into order. When they had put up the pavilions (*khaima*) and tents (*khar-gah*) and the audience tent (*bar-gah*), the Emperor came to see the camp and the splendid set-out, and visited the begams and his sisters. As he dismounted somewhat near Ma'suma Begam's (tent), he honoured her with a visit. All of us, the

begams and my sisters, were in his society. When he went to any begam's or sister's quarters, all the begams and all his sisters used to go with him.³

Note the careful attention paid to precise rules: designated days to go to the other side of the river, the careful arrangement of the tents of women, the king himself coming to see the arrangement, the manner and timing of his visits, the deportment required of those who accompanied him, and so forth.

Now compare the above extracts with a statement on the Mughal *harem* that appears in K.S. Lal's *The Mughal Harem* (1988), one of the few academic accounts of the subject:

The term Mughal harem conjures up a vision of a sequestered place ensconcing beautiful forms in mysterious magnificence. . . . [T]he young girls were not exposed to all the celebrations in the *Mahal* [palace] in which sex orgies dominated or the master bargained for beauty and love on occasions. . . . Naturally, every lady of consequence tried to win the master's undivided love and openly competed to gain ascendancy in the harem. Women's beauty gave them a power as undefined as unique. . . . There were other tensions though not so deep in effect. These may be classed under the generic term jealousy. But on this we need not dwell much for the harem was not meant for the old and ailing. It was meant to be a bright place, an abode of the young and beautiful, an arbour of pleasure and retreat for joy.⁴

What we have here is the portrait of a sexualized, secluded, feminine domain (albeit not for the "old and ailing"), centrally premised on a crude principle of sensual pleasure that was supposed to regulate the "private" lives of imperial women and men. The single sentence on the *harem* in the volume on the Mughals in the "New Cambridge History of India" series' John F. Richards's *The Mughal Empire* (1993) reproduces this image: "Ideally, the harem provided a respite, a retreat for the nobleman and his closest male relatives—a retreat of grace, beauty, and order designed to refresh the males of the household."⁵ It is echoed again in R. Nath's description in his *Private Life of the Mughals* (1994). The emperor Jahangir, for instance, was in Nath's view "a sensuous person" who "indulged excessively" both in wine and women. "By a routine estimate, he had nearly 300 young and beautiful women attached to his bed, an incomprehensible figure in the modern age. This shows his over-indulgence in sex and his excessive engagement in the harem [*sic*]."⁶

This received image of Mughal private life has been powerful in blinding historians to the density and variation of domestic life projected in the contemporary records, such as Gulbadan Banu Begum's *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah*, which I use as my central counterpoint in this article. The extracts from Gulbadan's memoir cited at the beginning of this article, which could be set beside many others in her text, reveal a *harem* far different from that commonly presented to us. The complexity of relationships that emerges in these is notable. By contrast, the academic accounts that I juxtapose with the Begum's memoir appear devoid of any historical depth and unaware of the intricacy of relationships and activities and the multifaceted and intimate community found in the *harem*.

This article examines the possibility of writing a history of Mughal domestic life. In thinking about this question, I have not unearthed any new sources. Instead, I have returned to sources that have been available all along (imperial chronicles, ethical digests, visual representations, and architectural remains). This revisiting has involved listening to "peripheral" stories and voices, "drowned in the noise of statist commands."⁷ It has also meant looking at well-known but neglected sources (such as Gulbadan's memoir) and using them more centrally. The return to the mainstream official chronicles in the light of these peripheral sources is no less instructive for the many new insights it allows. On the basis of this "rediscovered" archive, then, I suggest several ways in which another history may be brought into view. I hope that this will be a gendered and more self-consciously political history that cannot simply be hived off as "supplementary," and that accounts such as the one I put forward here will serve to reopen other questions of central importance to Mughal history.

THE KINGS AND THE MEMOIRIST

As a first step, I provide a brief introduction to the Mughal memoirist Gulbadan Banu Begum and to the first three Mughal kings before I discuss the possibility of constructing a history of early Mughal domestic life through the Begum's memoir.

Zahir al-Din Muhammad Babur (1483-1530) was a descendent of the Mongol ruler Chingiz Khan (1167-1227) on his mother's side and Timur (1336-1405), the Turkic-Mongol ruler, on his father's. He spent most of his

life fighting with the princes of other Timurid territories in parts of Central Asia and Afghanistan. Most notable among these combats are Babur's long drawn-out struggles with the Uzbiks, the direct descendants of Chingiz Khan through his son Juchi. Defeated in these struggles to gain a territorial foothold, Babur was pushed to Afghanistan. He finally acquired a territorial base in Hindustan in 1526 by defeating Sultan Ibrahim Lodi of Delhi. Thus he laid the foundation of Mughal rule in India.

Nasir al-Din Humayun (1508-1556), Babur's son, encountered massive difficulties in retaining his father's conquests in India. The biggest challenge to his kingship came from Sher Khan Sur who ruled southern Bihar in eastern India. After being defeated by Sher Khan in 1540 near Kanauj, Humayun became an exile in Persia and parts of Afghanistan. In 1554, however, he led his army back and fought a victorious battle and restored the Mughal monarchy. What is called the Mughal "empire" of India with all its pomp and splendor came to be securely established only in the time of Jalal al-Din Muhammad Akbar (1542-1605), the son of Humayun.

Gulbadan Banu Begum was the daughter of Babur, sister of Humayun, and aunt of Akbar. She was born in 1523 in Afghanistan and traveled to Hindustan (to Agra) at the age of six, after Babur had made some substantial conquests in that region. Her mother was Dildar Begum, but Maham Begum, the senior wife of Babur, took charge of her. As her memoir reveals, Gulbadan witnessed the early turmoil of Babur and Humayun's reigns: she and her husband, Khizr Khvajeh Khan, seem to have spent much of their time wandering with what may be described as her peripatetic Mughal family home.⁸

Gulbadan was thus a close witness to the making of the Mughal monarchy, seeing it through many vicissitudes—from the inception of the Mughal kingdom in the early conquests of Babur to its established splendor in Akbar's reign. She came to write about all this at the behest of her nephew, Akbar, whose efforts to consolidate and institutionalize Mughal power included the command that a comprehensive and authoritative official history be written of its early stages and of his reign. It was in this context that Gulbadan wrote her *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah*.

THE RECEIVED HISTORY

It is perhaps not too far-fetched to suggest that India's anticolonial nationalism has provided the framework for the most important recent writings on Mughal history. In line with the nationalist agenda, Mughal historians have labored (explicitly or implicitly) to demonstrate the political consolidation and "unity" of India under the Mughals, the autonomous development of the subcontinent, and even its secular inclinations. Indeed many Mughal histories have been written as if the empire was no more than a preamble to "modern" India. Since the 1950s, historians of Mughal India have concentrated heavily on the political administrative institutions of Mughal rule. Closely allied to these are studies focused on agrarian conditions, economic change, trade relations, and the attendant class struggles. There has been considerable writing in the area of what might be called a socio-economic history, both in the context of agrarian relations and in that of trade and trading networks.

Apart from the close and detailed investigation of political, military, revenue, and agrarian matters, the Mughal court has also been studied selectively, mainly as a site for factions and party politics. In most of these histories of the Mughal court and political institutions, the premise of investigation is that these are sites of "high" politics and that this political world is curiously unified.⁹ In addition, received histories treat these institutional sites as fully developed from the moment of their birth, fixed and knowable, if occasionally complicated in form. Numerous studies of the Mughal empire present it as it appears from the heyday of Akbar's rule from the capital cities Fatehpur-Sikri and Agra, with all its regal paraphernalia, grandeur and power, and project the picture backward to cover the time of his two predecessors.

What happens to the history of Mughal social life in this context? In the existing literature, this history takes two main forms. The first is a statement that appears under the generic title "social conditions and life of the people." This amounts to no more than a journalistic listing of items of daily use and festivities and pastimes, which are described in such general, commonsensical terms that they give the reader a history that seems to be valid for all times.¹⁰ Within this genre of Mughal social histories, another remaindered category may be noted: "culture," which refers to works of

art, architecture, and intellectual life. When it is not glossed in the journalistic manner pointed above, this area becomes the domain of specialists (art for art's sake): art forms, history of styles, painting techniques, varieties of artifacts, and so forth. Where the historian retains a political concern, histories of Mughal art and architecture have demonstrated the splendor of the Mughal court as the legitimizing indicator of the rule and the glory of an emperor. It is only recently that historians have begun to question the thrust of this legacy and to make broader suggestions regarding the importance of architectural history for all Mughal historians.¹¹

More directly relevant to the subject of the current investigation is a second strand in Mughal social history, which is best described as belonging to the genre of biographies of “women worthies.” Studies of this kind focus on the visibility of imperial women and their power. An interesting feature of this writing is that it has come to be seen by male historians as sufficient to its subject (that is, women), and there has been little attempt to rethink long-held assumptions about Mughal court and society. At best, such biographies are seen as (mild) correctives: of course, there were women too—some of them quite talented! This reluctance to think about women's histories as “history” is obviously not restricted to Mughal historiography alone. There is greater irony here. Although these studies of Mughal women opened up a neglected area of investigation, the women biographers themselves excluded the possibility of querying or even raising new questions about the accepted boundaries of family and household, public and private spheres, gender relations and political power. In these biographies, one finds little to suggest that the communities of Mughal elite women were a part and parcel of imperial designs and the making of this monarchy and therefore that an investigation of their lives and conditions is vital to any understanding of it.

Rekha Misra wrote an early book in this style of reinstating Mughal women to “history,” with an appropriately indicative title, *Women in Mughal India* (1967). It is a study of the visible aristocratic Mughal women (who had been given a place in the imperial records or the narratives of European travelers) in the form of biographical sketches, in which the author unsurprisingly ended up with a fairly close replication of the sources. Twenty-three years later this was still the dominant trend in writings on Mughal

women. In 1990, Renuka Nath wrote a book in the same biographical mode, merely adding a few more elite women to Misra's list. In 1993, Ellison Banks Findly produced another biography, far more detailed than the above, but following pretty much in the footsteps of her predecessors. The subject here is Nur Jahan, wife of Jahangir (the fourth Mughal emperor), the "Empress of Mughal India" as Findly calls her.¹² What is astonishing is that these relatively conventional works of the 1990s are produced at a time of lively, engaged debates concerning feminist historiography and the agency of women high and low.¹³

There have nonetheless been some significant exceptions to the kind of social history outlined above. Aside from Tapan Raychaudhuri's early and unusual investigation of social life under the reign of Akbar and Jahangir in Bengal, several recent writings have opened up new avenues of analysis in the realm of Mughal social history. The work of Stephen Blake on the Mughal imperial capital, Shahjahanabad, in the years 1639-1739, for example, examines the structure of the imperial household. He makes the case that the Mughal state was a patrimonial bureaucratic structure, in which the emperor and his household were of overwhelming importance. Historians like John Richards, Burton Stein, Noboru Karashima, and G. Berkemer have accepted Blake's formulations, albeit with slight modifications. Following this line of enquiry, Rosalind O'Hanlon has recently examined the construction of an imperial masculinity under Akbar as part of the strategy of governance under the third Mughal monarch.¹⁴

However, this welcome attention to the changing images of power, the willful construction of imperial "charisma" and the related details of spatial arrangements and bodily regulation, still tends to remain excessively emperor-centered. In spite of their proposition that the imperial household was the model on which other realms of the empire (the court and the society-at-large) were to be built, neither Blake nor O'Hanlon pays much attention to the activities and relationships—or even the identity—of the other inhabitants of the imperial family. Thus we find little discussion of how the denizens of the inner apartments adopted and negotiated prescriptive norms, and of how these were contested and negotiated. Even the king appears in these accounts as an abstract category, produced in the frame of inherited ethical moral texts. When the figure of the monarch is

represented in this way, it is not surprising that the king's intimate circle, the invisible members of the domestic world—who struggled to fashion themselves and surely contributed to the emergence of new attitudes, values, and behavior—form little part of the investigations.

THE QUESTION OF SOURCES

How then might we work toward an alternative history of the Mughals, one that takes distance from the legacy of overwhelmingly political, administrative, and institutional accounts and of those social histories in which history is presented in such static terms that it gives the reader an image of royalty valid for all times and places? The first thing to do is to challenge the received wisdom that surviving sources are inadequate.

The discussion that follows, centering on the question of the archive in the time of the first three Mughal kings, should help to show that the inadequacy of source materials is only part—and perhaps a small part—of the problem. Let us begin with an examination of the records that make up the accepted archive for early Mughal times. For Babur, his memoir, the *Baburnama*, and the *Tarikh-i Rashidi* of his cousin Muhammad Haydar Dughlat, have remained the most popular texts for scholars. Babur wrote the *Baburnama* mainly between 1526–1529 in his native Turkic language, known today as Chaghatay.¹⁵ The text was translated into Persian in the court of Akbar. Muhammad Haydar Dughlat spent most of his career in Kabul. He was in close contact with Babur during this period, and his work (composed in 1545–1546) is valuable as it highlights the political and cultural intricacies of those parts of Central Asia and Afghanistan that Babur was dealing with at the time.

The chronicles used most extensively for information on Humayun's reign are the following: the *Qanun-i Humayuni*, an account of the rules and ordinances of the king's reign, composed in 1534 by one of his officials, Khvandamir, and the *Tazkirat-ul-Vaqi'at*, a rather candid account put together in 1587 by Jawhar Aftabchi, Humayun's ewer-bearer.¹⁶ Then there is the *Tazkireh-i Humayun va Akbar* of Bayazid Bayat, an officer of Humayun. This is a history of the reigns of Humayun and Akbar from 1542 to 1591, which was completed in 1590–1591.¹⁷ The first official history of the Mughal court was commissioned by Akbar, and the biographies by Jawhar

Aftabchi and Bayazid Bayat mentioned above were produced in response to his order that servants of the state record their impressions of past times as part of the process of collecting material for the book. The resulting volume, *Akbarnama* (completed in 1596), and its official and equally voluminous appendix, the *A`in-i Akbari* (an administrative and statistical report on Akbar's government in all its branches), written by a close friend and courtier of the emperor, Abu'l Fazl `Allami, have remained the most important sources for all histories of his reign. Apart from the *Akbarnama*, the *Muntakhab-ut-Tavarikh* of `Abd al-Qadir Badauni, a severe critic of Akbar's policies who wrote his history in secret, has also been important. Historians have found the *Muntakhab-ut-Tavarikh* a useful counter to the panegyric account of Abu'l Fazl `Allami. In the same way, scholars have found a neutral middle ground in the cautious, evenhanded manner of description of the *Tabaqat-i Akbari*, written by another member of Akbar's court, Nizam al-Din Ahmad.¹⁸

For a long time now, a canonical position has been ascribed to these kinds of sources. The choice of certain sources as basic and central has in turn tended to perpetuate certain kinds of histories. The interest in agrarian, administrative, and institutional histories, for example, has made chronicles such as the *Akbarnama* and the *A`in-i Akbari* appear essential to any undertaking in Mughal history. The *Akbarnama* and the *A`in-i Akbari* have been singled out as "foundational" sources in this way, not only because of their supposed "accuracy" and "objectivity," but because they are official compilations dealing directly with political administrative matters—and closest in that sense to a modern state's archive. Relying on texts such as the *Akbarnama*, historians have often uncritically reproduced the primary sources themselves and therefore duplicated one or another chronicler's assessments of the empire, imperial relations, and other related matters. In this way many of our modern histories have turned out to be not very different from the primary text (or texts) out of which they are constructed.

Harbans Mukhia's well-known study entitled *Historians and Historiography during the Reign of Akbar* (1976) serves to illustrate my point about the pivotal position ascribed to certain Mughal sources. In the three central chapters of the book, the author discusses the three "major" historians of Akbar's

empire: Abu'l Fazl `Allami, `Abd al-Qadir Badauni, and Nizam al-Din Ahmad. He goes on in his penultimate chapter to discuss "Some Minor Historical Works Written during Akbar's Reign." While reading this chapter, I expected to find Gulbadan's text among the "minor historical works." Instead, all we find is a footnote in which the author explains why he has not included Gulbadan's memoir. "The reason is," he explains, "that I feel I have practically nothing to add to what its translator, Mrs. Beveridge, has said in her introduction to the translation."¹⁹

Mukhia's comment invites some reflection. His reasons for not including the Begum's memoir in his monograph stem partly of course from the fact that the author distinguishes between major (political, administrative, and emperor-centered) and minor sources (of royal women, servants, and so forth), privileging the "hard politics" of the former against the "soft society" of the latter. The presumption of the supposedly central character of some sources, as opposed to the peripheral (or minor) status of others, derives in this case from a belief that despite limitations, certain texts like the *Akbarnama* are authentic because they were based on "official documents as well as memoirs of persons involved in, or witness to, the events."²⁰ Mukhia, of course, is not alone in this belief in the "authenticity," hence "reliability," of these sources.²¹

It is in this troubling context of a rather simple (transparent) reading, if you will, of the Mughal archive that I wish to explore the "minor" text, the *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah*, left to us by Gulbadan Banu Begum and to show by a critical engagement with it, how many hidden dimensions of Mughal history may yet be probed.

THE CHALLENGE OF A PRINCESS'S MEMOIR

In 1587, in preparation for the writing of the *Akbarnama*, Akbar issued an order to the "servants of the State" and "old members of the Mughal family" to write down or relate their impressions of earlier times.²² It was in accordance with this order that Gulbadan Banu Begum produced her memoir.²³

What Gulbadan wrote, however, was no panegyric. Her writing was markedly different from anything that others produced at the time (including biographies, exemplary accounts, chronological narratives, and normative accounts), as the list of the sources used for the compila-

tion of the *Akbarnama* shows.²⁴ Interestingly, the genre title that Gulbadan chose was different from all of these: *ahval*, a word meaning conditions, state, circumstances, or situations.²⁵ Does this title index a different conception of what a history of the times should be? It is not possible to give a straightforward answer to this question. A disadvantage is that only one copy of Gulbadan's *Ahval* survives today.²⁶ This manuscript, now held at the British Library, is incomplete, ending abruptly some three years before Akbar's accession.

Turki was Gulbadan's native language, and one can trace many Turki words in the Persian manuscript. Yet we do not know if she wrote both in Turki and in Persian. From Humayun's time on, the influence of Persian had clearly increased in the Mughal court. Gulbadan Banu Begum, his sister is almost certain to have learned the language as she grew up in these surroundings. By the time she wrote her memoir, Persian had already been declared the language of administration at all levels. As Muzaffar Alam puts it, it had emerged as "*the language of the king, the royal household and the high Mughal elite.*" The nomination of Gulbadan Begum to write a memoir of the times, as well as the Persian verse attributed to her, indicates her standing as a "learned" person.²⁷

For all that, we know little about Gulbadan's total literary output or her education. We cannot know therefore what models the Begum drew on to write her own text. It is without any didactic purpose, and lies outside the "mirror for princes" genre that seems to have been prevalent then. Gulbadan read some contemporary memoirs and chronicles of the kings, including her father's memoir, but the *Baburnama* was clearly not the literary model for her *Ahval*.²⁸ Annette Beveridge tells us that the Begum had a copy of Bayazid Bayat's *Tazkireh-i Humayun va Akbar* in her library, and that she found a copy of Khvandamir's *Qanun-i Humayuni* inscribed with the Begum's name.²⁹ Yet Gulbadan did not imitate the styles of either of these accounts, which were in any case contemporaneous with her own and perhaps unavailable at the time of her writing. The *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah* might thus be classed as an "open" text belonging to no recognized genre.

Whatever we may conclude about the problems of authorship and of personal memory, given the uncertainties surrounding the Begum's memoir, one thing is clear. If most chronicles of the age aimed to be

authoritative histories in the manner of the generic (panegyric) histories of rulers, Gulbadan moved away from this genre to produce an account of far more modest incidents in the lives of Babur and Humayun. Her account of the everyday lives of this royal family in peripatetic circumstances is a unique piece of writing. Even a brief description of the contents and the organization of *Ahwal* serves to illustrate this point. The surviving copy of the memoir is divided into two parts. In the first part, Gulbadan discusses the period of her father Babur's life. This includes detail quite similar to that contained in Babur's memoir, about his peripatetic life, his wars and victories at the time, and the early years of his establishment of Mughal rule in Hindustan. The specialness of the Begum's memoir, however, is to be found in the images she provides of her father's "home" life: extensive information about his marriages, his wives and children, and his relationships with his kith and kin, especially the senior women of the Mughal lineage. The memoir is remarkable not only for this rare account of domestic life, but also for the complexity that the author brings out in those episodes that are discussed in other chronicles of the time. Consider the inventory of gifts and instructions for their presentation that I mentioned at the beginning of this article. In his own brief discussion of the same event, Babur makes only a casual, and far less interesting, mention of the presents.³⁰

The second part of Gulbadan's memoir begins on the nineteenth folio with the reign of her brother, Humayun. Here too, alongside a discussion of the king's expeditions and reconquest of Hindustan, the memoir provides other kinds of fascinating information. We learn of Mughal women lost during wars, as well as of Akbar's birth in the harsh circumstances of the itinerant lives of Humayun and his wife, Hamideh Banu Begum. Gulbadan's record of royal women's articulations about how they should marry are telling. So is her elaboration of Humayun's frequent visits to the senior women of the family and the tension that arose between him and his wives owing to these continual visits. Add to these the impressive detail provided about the celebrations and feasts held by the senior women on various occasions, and we have a lost world of the court in camp brought to life in a way that no other chronicle of the time even approaches.

Gulbadan's substantial treatment of the involvement of several Mughal women in moments of marriage, childbirth, "adoption," and death; in the celebrations of feasts; and in times of strategy and planning points to the complex web of people and practices involved with the processes of early Mughal imperial formation. In her memoir, we hear of forbidden feelings, hierarchical but intimate relationships, and acts contrary to the logic of imperial power. In this way, we are reminded of the flesh and blood of historical figures, well known and not so well known, as well as the limitations and inventiveness of their lives. What the text provides is a rich, inflected sense of the domestic lives of the early Mughals.

The two extracts from the *Ahwal-i Humayun Badshah* cited in the first section of this article are enough to indicate the kinds of questions that the text immediately raises, and that it is necessary for us to ask about the imbrication of the Mughal domestic world in the everyday life of the courts and kings or, equally, the imbrication of courts and kings in the everyday life of the domestic world. Let me discuss one more episode to delineate further the potential of Gulbadan's memoir. The event that I consider here is described in the accounts of both Jawhar and Gulbadan. It concerns the place and meanings of negotiation in a royal marriage, and shows how Mughal women and men were partners in the production not only of heirs but also in the enhancement of imperial rituals and of "correct" ways of being and conducting oneself.

In the midst of a protracted war between Humayun and his stepbrother Kamran, there was a brief pause when Humayun permitted Kamran to march to Kabul and he himself left for Bikaner. At Pat, Humayun's stepmother Dildar Begum organized an entertainment "at which all the ladies of the court were present." Among these was Hamideh Banu Begum, the daughter of the preceptor of another of his stepbrothers, Mirza Hindal. Humayun made enquiries about her and stated his wish to marry her. On hearing this, Mirza Hindal is reported to have said: "I thought you came here to do me honour, not to look out for a young bride. . . ." This displeased Humayun, and he left. Dildar Begum then patched up matters: "you [Hindal] are speaking very improperly to his Majesty, whom you ought to consider as the representative of your late father." Dildar Begum gave "a nuptial banquet" the next day, "after which she delivered the

young lady to his Majesty, and gave them her blessing.” Humayun and Hamideh Banu Begum then proceeded to Bhakkar.³¹ Mirza Hindal’s response to Humayun’s expressed desire to marry Hamideh Banu Begum, and Dildar Begum’s firm chiding of Hindal are both statements about the necessity and importance of correct behavior in the matter of seeking brides and making marriages, as also in interaction between a younger and older brother.

The above details are found in the *Tazkirat-ul-vaqi`at* of Jawhar. However, the same affair is given a somewhat different rendering in Gulbadan’s *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah*. Although the account of Hindal and Humayun’s argument over Hamideh Banu Begum and of Dildar Begum’s intervention is very similar, what Jawhar’s memoir does not mention, but Gulbadan’s does, is that Hamideh Banu Begum initially refused to be married to Humayun. Gulbadan reports an exchange between Hamideh Banu Begum and Dildar Begum. The former objected when she was invited to Dildar Begum’s quarters on Humayun’s insistence: “If it is to pay my respects, I was exalted by paying my respects the other day. Why should I come again?” For forty days, according to Gulbadan, Hamideh Banu Begum resisted seeing Humayun a second time. Finally, Dildar Begum advised her, “After all you will marry someone. Better than a king who is there?” Hamideh Banu Begum’s reported response was: “Oh yes, I shall marry someone; but he shall be a man whose collar my hand can touch, and not one whose skirt it does not reach.”³²

What is important in Gulbadan’s rendering is not the facticity (or literal veracity) of this exchange between Dildar Begum and Hamideh Banu Begum, but the fact that she was willing to put such a conversation into her text. This says something about her understanding of the cultural practices of the time. One may thus see Gulbadan’s account of Hamideh Banu Begum’s reluctance as a statement about continuous debate, and tension, in matters of appropriate behavior in the lives of people at the court. In one of the communications that Hamideh Banu Begum is supposed to have sent to the emperor, she says: “To see kings once is lawful [*jayiz ast*]; a second time it is forbidden [*na-mahram ast*]. I shall not come.” Humayun responds to the concern implicit in Hamideh Banu Begum’s refusal to visit him a second time: “If she is not a consort [*na-mahram-and*], we will make her a consort [*mahram misazim*].”³³ Their marriage follows.

The marriage of Humayun and Hamideh Banu Begum shows that women's choice in matters of matrimony was a matter of widespread concern, as were genealogy and dynasty, especially in the Timurid-Mughal context. In this instance the details of the negotiation of marriage are especially striking for the careful attention paid to tradition, protocol, and legality, and to the minute rules of social interaction—the number of times it was legitimate (*jayiz*) to visit a king, the equal status that had to be sought in marriages, as well as the importance of getting married when a king desired to enter into a relationship with a noble woman.

QUESTIONS OF TRANSLATION

Annette Beveridge, the colonial scholar, accomplished the truly commendable task of unearthing, translating, and presenting the *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah* to the scholarly world. Yet it would be surprising if, one hundred years on, we did not have some questions about the way in which that work was done. The process by which Gulbadan's memoir was made available to us, and the mutations that took place in the course of that process, need to be borne in mind by the modern historian.

As a first step, it will help to keep in mind Beveridge's own social and intellectual context. She was born Annette Akroyd (1842-1929) in Stourbridge, a small town just west of Birmingham, England. A daughter of "a self-made man of England's rising middle class," she was brought up as a Unitarian in religion and "radical" in politics.³⁴ In 1861, she enrolled at the Unitarian-supported Bedford College in London. Her education was shaped by the ideology of nineteenth-century scientism, with an added emphasis on domestic and personal life.³⁵ She shared the nineteenth century's unquestioned belief in science's objectivity and its ability to "represent" reality. In this triumphalist vision, the institutions, practices, traditions, and belief-systems of the West were rational, and those of other (non-Western) parts of the world were presented as being backward, if not uncivilized. Beveridge's public opposition to the Ilbert Bill of 1883, seeking to empower Indian civil servants with criminal jurisdiction over European subjects in country stations, was very much in accord with these views.³⁶

How does this self-confident colonial context affect Beveridge's translation of the *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah*? The first point to note is that the Vic-

torian translator's fixed frame of knowledge also "fixes" the stories she reads in the *Akhal*. As a result, numerous interesting nuances are lost and what appears before the reader is a flattened picture of early Mughal domestic life. This may be witnessed in Beveridge's literal paraphrasing in many instances and in her attempt to find exact English equivalents of Persian words that have complex histories and associations. It may also be seen in the "aristocratic" (yet colonial bourgeois) sensibility with which she regards the characters of the memoir.

Consider this passage, which evokes marriage practices in the time of Humayun. In the memoir, the conversation between Maham Begum and others is placed two years after Babur's death (1532) when Humayun was trying to retain and expand his father's territories in India. In Beveridge's translation, Gulbadan writes:

My lady, who was Maham Begam, had a great longing and desire to see a son of Humayun. Wherever there was a good-looking and nice girl, she used to bring her into his service. Maywa-jan, a daughter of Khadang [? Khazang], the chamberlain (*yasawal*), was in my employ. One day (after) the death of his Majesty *Firdaus-makani*, my lady said: "Humayun, Maywa-jan is not bad. Why do you not take her into your service?" So, at her word, Humayun married and took her that very night.

Three days later Bega Begam came from Kabul. She became in the family way. In due time she had a daughter, whom they named 'Aqiqa. Maywa-jan said to Lady (*Aka*) Maham Begam, "I am in the family way, too." Then my lady got ready two sets of weapons, and said: "Whichever of you bears a son, I will give him good arms." . . . [She] was very happy, and kept saying: "Perhaps one of them will have a son." She kept watch till Bega Begam's 'Aqiqa was born. Then she kept an eye on Maywa-jan. Ten months went by. The eleventh also passed. Maywa-jan said: "My maternal aunt was in Mirza Ulugh Beg's *haram*. She had a son in the twelfth month; perhaps I am like her." So they sewed tents and filled pillows. But in the end everyone knew she was a fraud.³⁷

"My lady Maham Begam, had a great longing and desire to see a son of Humayun," Gulbadan tells us. In this world, as elsewhere, it was the role of the younger wives to produce heirs; in their turn, at a later stage, they themselves instructed younger wives about such responsibilities. This duty of elder women to advise the young and of the young to carry forward the name of the family through reproduction was of no small mo-

ment in the Timurid-Mughal world. Maywa-jan and her “services” would fit this tradition. The production of royal children was a much-desired event, for such an esteemed birth meant the perpetuation of the eminent Timurid-Mughal family. The task was especially crucial in the time of Babur and Humayun when the risk of the disappearance of the family was very real, on account of the Uzbek threat that Babur faced in Central Asia, and later because of the Afghan challenge encountered by Humayun in Hindustan. It was an urgent requirement in these circumstances to preserve the lineage, and, to achieve that, marriages and the birth of children was essential. It was in this context that Maham Begum made the point about male heirs. She looked for wives for Humayun for the momentous task of producing heirs to the throne.³⁸

In her discussion of the episode described above, Beveridge draws the following picture of Maham Begum:

Maham Begam was a clever woman, and both as wife and as widow made herself felt in her home. Lady Rosebody [Gulbadan Banu Begum] lifts the *parda* and shows us the Empress-mother busied in duties not often thus disclosed to the outside eye. In telling the story, which for the sake of its many special points we quote in full, she has no air of being indiscreet, and is, as may be seen, quite matter-of-fact.³⁹

Beveridge sees in Maham’s activities more “a clever . . . Empress-mother” than a senior woman with wisdom, status, and authority, who would have seen it as her duty to advise and guide her younger kinsfolk and to sustain the name and honor of her family. She elevates this “elder” to a rarefied and singular position that is far removed from the projection of plural, and sometimes overlapping, circles of intimates and authorities in the peripatetic Mughal world of Gulbadan’s memoir.

Indeed, according to Gulbadan’s memoir, a striking characteristic of the early Mughal domestic world seems to be that kinship networks were extended to form new familial communities. The talk of blood remained, but the idea of consanguinity was also built around practices such as wet-nursing and notions of fostering. Many of Akbar’s nurses and their husbands were to become influential in his court. Their many-sided participation in the affairs of the monarchy shows how these relationships and communities continued to shape notions of family and kinship, and court politics itself.

In this context of highly open and variegated domestic relations, the attribution of “cleverness” and “singularity” to Maham Begum by Beveridge is perhaps too hasty. One example of this kind of slanting, which is accompanied by an assimilation of early Mughal society and mores into something more recognizably Victorian, is the use of the honorific “My Lady” for *Akam* and other cognate terms. This form of address is found dispersed throughout the translation, as also in the first line of the extract from Gulbadan that we have been considering here. Beveridge ponders over the meaning of “*Akam*” at one point. She writes: “the Turki Aka is used as a title of respect from a junior to a senior. It has also the sense ‘elder brother,’ which makes application to a woman doubtful. Babar uses the word . . . and Mr. Erskine [a contemporary scholar of Beveridge] suggests to read ‘my Lady’ [sic].”⁴⁰ Beveridge declares it hard to find the equivalent word for *akam* in English, but her eventual choice of “My Lady” fails to capture the tone of affection and respect in the original and calls up inappropriate associations with elevation and romance in the late-medieval European (knightly) tradition. *Aka*, a Turki word (used for men), is close in essence to *khanum* or *begum*. Reverence, privileged status, and deference (that came with enhanced age) are marked characteristics of all of these words, and they are somewhat lost in Beveridge’s more rarefied phrase.

In a similar way, we might ask questions about the word *havasak* in the translation cited above. In the last line of the passage, the word “fraud” is used for the Persian word *havasak*. The latter, which is not found as such in Persian dictionaries, is an affective diminutive of *havas*, meaning desire, caprice. Although Beveridge interprets *havasak* as a pejorative, Maywa-jan’s craving for a child is hardly unexpected, given the Timurid-Mughal context of the politics of marriage and reproduction, and the quick dismissal of her state as “fraudulent”—rather than, say, as a case of hysterical pregnancy—amounts to a reduction of the ambivalence and tension that marks Gulbadan’s text.⁴¹

Despite the evident problems of translation, it is not difficult to see the memoir’s rich potential in helping us comprehend the processes at work in the making of the Mughal monarchy and its domestic world. Against the background of fragments from the *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah*, it is possible to consider the conditions and ways of domestic life under the early

Mughals. Gulbadan's documentation of the place and responsibilities of Mughal women and men allows us to explore the meanings of relationships and the kinds of conflict, and solidarities, making for diverse forms of community among them. Different kinds of relationships are indexed in the participation of women and men in the making of marriages, in festivities and other celebrations, and in the observance of rituals at births and deaths and more everyday occasions. It is through an excavation of these relationships and events that we are able to delineate forms of Mughal sociability as well as think through other concepts: those of motherhood and wifehood, for instance; the ways in which marriages were effected (and why in those ways); or the prevailing notions of duty, loyalty, and love.⁴²

Gulbadan thus allows us to imagine the domestic life of the early Mughals as a realm in which many different kinds of duties and activities, bonds of solidarity, notions of sexuality, questions of reproduction and reproductive rights (and duties), and varying moments of celebration and joy and loss and grief come together. She takes us through the complex set of relations in which women of the nobility were involved in the domestic sphere, pointing to the public political affairs that were necessarily conducted here as well as in the courts, and through all this to the very different meanings attaching to family, married life, and domestic affairs in this sixteenth-century world.

CONCLUDING THOUGHTS

If the multiplex character of Gulbadan's memoir opens some fascinating arenas for us, it also helps us read other Mughal chronicles very differently, for these too are richer in meaning and content than the historians have made them out to be.

In histories of the Mughals, there is a sharp focus on the personality and politics of the Mughal kings and their most prominent lieutenants. The emperor, his nobles, and their political military exploits are explored over and over again; other worlds are hardly even noticed. There are two problems that flow from this. First, as feminist writings have shown in so many other contexts, a large part of human experience falls outside "history." This happens partly because ordinary, everyday, domestic events are not

neatly documented by the state or institutionalized in public archives. As a consequence, the account of the great historical changes and developments also fails to come to life. Few Mughal histories have been histories of people building lives, relationships, or domestic worlds; and even the description of the momentous and the extraordinary sometimes becomes empty. Gulbadan's *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah* draws our attention to the importance of the quotidian at the very moment of extraordinary, momentous events.

The challenge of her memoir may be summed up in many ways. Perhaps the easiest point to note is that she raises important questions about life and activities in the household of the early Mughals. Gulbadan's text poses a second, and less obvious, challenge too. Gulbadan shows us the Mughal empire in a very different light from that of the official histories and much of its subsequent historiography. Her empire is not yet fully institutionalized. Although Gulbadan's text was actually used as a source for the official chronicle of Akbar's empire, interestingly it is her text, and not the imperial history, that tells us about the *making of the empire*. What the *Akbarnama* (and the *A'in-i Akbari*) provides is an institutionalized history of an empire already in place—fully formed, so to speak. Gulbadan's text, by contrast, shows us the empire (and its history) *being formed*.

Thus her *Ahval* appears important in at least three ways. First, chronologically speaking, it evokes a powerful impression of an empire that is not already known or made, a political formation taking unsteady steps from infancy to maturity. Second, in terms of domestic manners and emotional life, the text provides much food for thought on the less tangible (and less documentable) aspects of Mughal history. Finally, on the question of history (and empire) itself, the text serves as a symbol of how official "history" came to be written. Of course, Gulbadan's memoir ended up as historiographical flotsam, suggesting both the entrenched politics and the machinations involved in the construction of historical archives.

Once we have been alerted to some of these hidden dimensions of Mughal history by a text like Gulbadan's, we discover that the canonical, mainstream sources long used by Mughal historians themselves yield information on many "hidden" matters when we go to them with new questions: unusual and unexpected evidence on the rough and tumble of

social life; on everyday struggles, fears, and pleasures; on the construction of new subjectivities and new historical conditions.

Consider an extraordinary moment that brings together the power of Akbar's regime on the one hand and the contrary nodes of power on the other: the pilgrimage to Mecca undertaken by the women of Akbar's *harem* in 1578. This pilgrimage should be set in the context of Akbar's reign in which courtly and domestic spaces came, for the first time, to be distinctly separated from each other. A neatly compartmentalized *harem* (*shabistan-i Iqbal*), designed to place women in a strictly segregated place, now appeared—for “good order and propriety,” Abu'l Fazl argued.⁴³ Akbar's chosen chronicler devoted a full chapter, *A'in 15*, to the imperial regulations of the *harem*, the first official statement on the royal household in the career of Mughal dynasty. In this statement, the women were officially designated the *pardah-giyan*, the veiled ones. This increased the invisibility of the royal women, now more elevated and at the same time more secluded than ever before. The theory of Akbar's empire, seen to good effect in the organization of the sacred, incarcerated *harem*, was however never so successful as to wipe out contradictions, tensions, human volition, or unexpected departures—all that is the stuff of human history. Although in the changing environment of Akbar's reign, a great deal was done to regulate the domestic arrangements, there is (not surprisingly) considerable evidence—like this *hajj* of imperial women led by Gulbadan Begum—to show how women and men continued to negotiate the prescriptive, thereby appropriating, translating, and recasting the imperial vision in many ways.

It is interesting to note that the most detailed account of this women's *hajj* is in fact contained in Abu'l Fazl's official compendium, the *Akbarnama*. Although this unique *hajj* may be seen as a sign of the “Islamic” claims of this polyglot empire, this journey, at the same time, maps the desires and agency of imperial women. The *hajj* of Gulbadan and her relations shows us the kinds of activities that were still possible in the red sandstone palaces of Fatehpur-Sikri and Agra in the late sixteenth century.⁴⁴ It was a bold and significant adventure, given the constraints of the passage and other restrictive circumstances, and one that was largely initiated and planned by the elder women. This collective women's pilgrimage remains an unparalleled event in the annals of the Mughals, highlighting for us

that although Akbar's *harem* was secluded, sacred, and even inaccessible to most people, it was by no means closed off from the world, unconcerned with politics, or bereft of power or interest in public affairs.

We never hear of such an incident again in the reigns of Akbar's well-established successors. Although people continued to perform the *hajj* under the later Mughals, the extraordinary venture of a group of royal women going on a pilgrimage was never to be witnessed again. Is this because the empire was now too well established? Or because the royal women, now better "incarcerated," had far less opportunity to take exceptional initiatives and set off on such a pilgrimage? Indeed, the royal women's *hajj* led by Gulbadan Begum comes as a startling discovery because, although the *Akbarnama* provides considerable detail about the *hajj*, historians have paid little or no attention to it.⁴⁵ Once such challenging complexities are noted in one set of materials, it is to be hoped that the historian will look at other texts with a different eye.

Thus, the easily available but neglected memoir of a Mughal princess enables us to raise questions about a Mughal "becoming" that Mughal historians have all too often skirted. This relates both to the coming into being of an empire, and to the simultaneous institution of an archive. By making it possible for us to see how one of the most vaunted Mughal sources (the *Akbarnama*) came into being, rendering its own "sources" peripheral as it did so, the memoir opens up the question of the *making* of sources, even as it raises questions about the assigned limits of Mughal history.

Gulbadan's text challenges some of Mughal historiography's most beloved propositions, such as the one that the sources are simply not available for this or that inquiry. Sensitized by the Begum's account of the struggles involved in the establishment of a new royal life and culture, one also learns what other ("central," official) frequently mined sources are capable of telling us about these processes. For what Gulbadan's *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah* suggests very clearly indeed is the fact of the fluidity and contestation that went into the founding of this new polity in its new setting—not only its new power and grandeur, but also its new regulations and accommodations, its traditions and its hierarchies. Her writing points to the history of a subjectivity and a culture, of political power and of social relationships, *struggling* to be born. Historians wishing to extend the

frontiers of Mughal history cannot but ask, as part of this endeavor, for a more sustained history of everyday lives and associations based on sources such as Gulbadan's memoir, but hardly on that alone.

NOTES

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A Note on Transliteration and Citations. There is no standard system for transliteration from Persian into English. I have used the modified version of the *International Journal of Middle East Studies* (IJMES) system developed and used by Layla S. Diba and Maryam Ekhtiar for their edited volume, *Royal Persian Paintings: The Qajar Epoch, 1785-1925* (New York: I.B. Taurus, publishers in association with the Brooklyn Museum of Art, 1998). For better readability, all diacritical marks have been removed. The original spellings have been retained in quotations. As a result, certain names appear with spellings in my text that differ from some spellings in the quotations. All the information included in square brackets is mine.

1. Gulbadan Banu Begum, *Ahval-i Humayun Badshah*, British Library MS, Or. 166; *The History of Humayun: Humayun Nama*, trans. Annette Susannah Beveridge, 2d ed. (1902; reprint, Delhi: Low Price Publications, 1994). I use the Persian manuscript and the English translation simultaneously in this article. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 94; see Gulbadan, *Ahval*, fol. 9b.
2. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 95-96; Gulbadan, *Ahval*, fol. 9b-10b.
3. A. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 129, 130; Begum, *Ahval*, fol. 29b-30a.
4. Kishori Saran Lal, *The Mughal Harem* (Delhi: Aditya Prakashan, 1988), 19, 135, 139, 143, 152.
5. John F. Richards, *The Mughal Empire* (Cambridge, U.K.: Cambridge University Press, 1993), 62.
6. R. Nath, *Private Life of the Mughals 1526-1803* (Jaipur: Historical Research Documentation Program, 1994), 13, 15, 17.
7. Ranajit Guha, "The Small Voice of History," in *Subaltern Studies IX: Writings on South Asian History and Society*, ed. Shahid Amin and Dipesh Chakrabarty (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1996), 3.

8. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 1, 8-9, 2.
9. See Satish Chandra, *Parties and Politics at the Mughal Court, 1707-1740* (Delhi: People's Publishing House, 1959); M. Athar Ali, *The Mughal Nobility under Aurangzeb* (London: Asia Publishing House, 1966); Richards, *The Mughal Empire*.
10. Ramesh Chandra Majumdar, ed., *The Mughul Empire* (Bombay: Bhartiya Vidya Bhavan, 1974).
11. Monica Juneja, ed., *Architecture in Medieval India* (New Delhi: Permanent Black, 2001).
12. Rekha Misra, *Women in Mughal India, 1526-1748* (Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1967). Renuka Nath, *Notable Mughal and Hindu Women in the Sixteenth and Seventeenth Centuries A.D.* (New Delhi: Inter-India Publications, 1990); Ellison Banks Findly, *Nur Jahan: Empress of Mughal India* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993).
13. To take only one example of an extraordinary book on the Ottoman imperial *harem* that came out the same year as Findly's, see Leslie P. Peirce, *The Imperial Harem: Women and Sovereignty in the Ottoman Empire* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993).
14. Tapan Raychaudhuri, *Bengal under Akbar and Jahangir* (Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1969); Stephen P. Blake, *Shahjahanabad: The Sovereign City in Mughal India, 1639-1739* (Cambridge, U.K.: Cambridge University Press, 1993); Hermann Kulke, ed., *The State in India, 1000-1700* (Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1997), 38; Rosalind O'Hanlon, "Kingdom, Household, and Body: Gender and the Construction of Imperial Service under Akbar," unpublished paper.
15. Zahir al-Din Muhammad Babur Mirza, *Baburnama*, trans. and ed. W.M. Thackston, parts 1-3, Turkish transcription, Persian edition, and English translation (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1993); and Annette Susannah Beveridge, trans., *Baburnama (Memoirs of Babur) of Zahiru'd-din Muhammad Babur Padshah Ghazi* (1921; reprint, Delhi: Low Price Publications, 1997); E. Denison Ross, trans. and N. Elias, ed., *The Tarikh-i Rashidi of Muhammad Haidar Dughlat: A History of the Moguls of Central Asia* (London: S. Low, Marston and Co., 1895).
16. M. Hidayat Hosain, ed., *The Qanun-i Humayuni of Khwandamir*, Bibliotheca Indica series 260, no. 1488, Persian text, Preface (Calcutta: Royal Asiatic Society of Bengal, 1940); Jawhar, *Tazkirat-ul-Vaqi'at: The Tezkereh al Vakiat or Private Memoirs of the Moghul Emperor Humayun*, trans. Charles Stewart (1832; reprint, Lucknow: Pustak Kendra, 1971).
17. M. Hidayat Hosain, ed., *Tadhkira-i Humayun wa Akbar of Bayazid Biyat*, Bibliotheca Indica series 264, no. 1546, Persian text (Calcutta: Royal Asiatic Society of Bengal, 1941).
18. Abu'l Fazl `Allami, *Akbarnama*, 3 vols., trans. Henry Beveridge, *The Akbar Nama of Abu-l-Fazl* (1902-39; reprint, Delhi: Low Price Publications, 1993); Abu'l Fazl `Allami, *Ain-i Akbari*, 3 vols., trans. H.F. Blochmann and H.S. Jarrett, *The A-in-I Akbari* (1873, 1894; reprint, Calcutta: Royal Asiatic Society, 1993); `Abd al-Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tavarikh*, trans. and ed. George S.A. Ranking, W.H. Lowe, and Wolseley Haig, *Muntakhabu-t-tavarikh*, vols. 1-3 (1884-1925; reprint, Delhi: Renaissance Publishing House, 1986); Nizam al-Din Ahmad, *Tabaqat-i Akbari*, 3 vols., trans. B. De and Baini Prasad, *The Tabaqat-i Akbari of Khwajah Nizamuddin Ahmad* (1936; reprint, Delhi: Low Price Publications, 1992).

19. Harbans Mukhia, *Historians and Historiography during the Reign of Akbar* (New Delhi: Vikas Publishing House, 1976), xvi, 154n1.
20. Mukhia, 71.
21. Ishtiaq Husain Qureshi, *Akbar: The Architect of the Mughul Empire* (1978; reprint, Delhi: Idarah-i-Adabiyat-i-Delli, 1987), 2, 6.
22. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 83, and n1.; Gulbadan, *Ahval*, fol. 2b; *Akbarnama*, 1: 29.
23. Henry Beveridge, "The Memoirs of Bayazid (Bajazet) Biyat," *Journal of the Asiatic Society of Bengal*, 62, parts 1-4 (1898): 296.
24. *Akbarnama*, vol. 1 (see introduction, esp. 29-33, including notes).
25. Francis Joseph Steingass, *A Comprehensive Persian-English Dictionary*, 2d ed.; and Soleyman Haim, *Shorter English Persian Dictionary*, 3d ed., see "ahval."
26. British Library, MSS Eur C176/ 221, 1-2; M.A. Scherer, "Woman to Woman: Annette, the Princess, and the Bibi," *Journal of Royal Asiatic Society*, 3d. series, 6 (1996): 208-9.
27. Muzaffar Alam, "The Pursuit of Persian: Language in Mughal Politics," *Modern Asian Studies* 32, no. 2 (1998): 324, 325; Annette Susannah Beveridge, "Life and Writings of Gulbadan Begam (Lady Rosebody)," *Calcutta Review* 106 (1892): 346-47.
28. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 83; Gulbadan, *Ahval*, fol. 2b.
29. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 76, 78.
30. *Baburnama*, trans. Thackston, 634-35; and *Babur-nama*, trans. A.S. Beveridge, 525-26.
31. *Tazkirat-ul-Vaqi`at*, 31.
32. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 150-51; Gulbadan, *Ahval*, fol. 43a.
33. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 151; Gulbadan, *Ahval*, fol. 43a.
34. Scherer, "Woman to Woman," 198.
35. Pat Barr, *The Memsahibs: The Women of Victorian India* (London: Secker and Warburg, 1976), 188-89; Scherer, "Woman to Woman," 197, 209; also, Scherer, "Annette Akroyd Beveridge: Victorian Reformer, Oriental Scholar" (Ph.D. diss., Ohio State University, 1995).
36. Mrinalini Sinha, *Colonial Masculinity: The "Manly Englishman" and the "Effeminate Bengali" in the Late Nineteenth Century* (Manchester, U.K.: Manchester University Press, 1995), 58-60; Scherer, "Annette Akroyd Beveridge," chap. 5.
37. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 112-13; Gulbadan, *Ahval*, fol. 21b-22a.
38. For an elaboration of these propositions, see my forthcoming book, "Domesticity and Power in the Early Mughal World" (Cambridge, U.K.: Cambridge University Press, forthcoming 2005).
39. A.S. Beveridge, "Gulbadan Begam," 353-54.
40. Beveridge, *Humayun*, 89-90.
41. The context of Timurid-Mughal reproductive politics might allow us to read *havasak* as a condition applicable to women who become desirous of having children and begin to have symptoms of pregnancy (swelling breasts and stomach, and milk production) without any biological conception of a child. Hysterical pregnancy, as it is termed in current medical terminology, is itself a fairly complex phenomenon. There are several realms in the spectrum of hysteria, thus acquiring many forms and underlying conditions. I am thankful to Dr. Ajay Wasan (research fellow at the

- Harvard Medical School) and Simone Taubenberger for these details.
42. Lal, "Domesticity and Power," chaps. 5 and 7.
 43. *Ain-i Akbari*, 1: 45.
 44. For details, see Lal, "Domesticity and Power," chap. 7.
 45. The single mention of Gulbadan Banu Begum in Richards's *The Mughal Empire* appears in a reference to the women's *haji*. The pilgrimage is represented as the initiative of the emperor Akbar and completely misses the initiative of the Begum; see also, Michael N. Pearson, *Pilgrimage to Mecca: The Indian Experience, 1500-1800* (Princeton, N.J.: Markus Wiener, 1996), esp. chap., "The Mughals and the *Haji*," 105-21.